

Championships. It's too soon to manifest a pattern here but the one positive certainly is that we have top class players across different events now, which was not the case some time ago. India has three Uber Cup medals, two of those from the recent past and that was largely because of Saina (Nehwal), Sindhu, Jwala (Gutta) and Ashwini.

Therefore, having a smooth singles and doubles combination becomes very important. Look at the men's side of things. We have three top class singles players, but even if we had two, we still have Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty. Doubles becomes important because it will come up somewhere in the first three matches of a team event. I won't call it a safety net, but a good doubles pair balances the team and is a big advantage. Doubles is something India seems to have finally got right. It was the missing piece.



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A diverse talent pool

Let's look at the personalities involved here, starting with Ashwini. To come in and be part of a team as a senior and playing with a younger partner comes with a bit of pressure. You know that there is a lot at stake and so, on one side, it demands it a little more on court but there's also the weight of Olympic qualification, so you're guarding against injury. Yet the unfortunate injury to Tanisha Crasto, forced Ashwini to pair up with Sindhu. They had to adapt and to just show that she is willing to do whatever it takes for the team was quite incredible.

The progress Treasa and Gayathri are showing as a pair is another shot in the arm for India. The best indicator isn't just that they're winning regularly, but it's about the kind of matches and the quality of opponents they're able to beat now. The draw is never in our hands, so the more you beat top-ranked players, the healthier your growth chart gets. What's interesting is, at one point, they were the favourites to for the Paris Olympics, but right now, there's competition between them



and Ashwini/Tanisha to make the cut. It's one thing to compete against an opponent, but to take on this qualification pressure is another story altogether. Then again, they train at P. Gopi Chand's academy, where these situations are not new. That makes a huge difference.

This also underlines why 17-year old debutante Anmol's story is such an incredible one because she has not yet had exposure to a setup like this. You can have personal expectations and ambitions, but she's not in an environment where Olympic medallists, world champions and world top ten players are training and walking in and out of the room.